

Learn English with the News

In today's lesson, I'm going to teach how you can use the news to boost your English learning. I've selected two articles that perfectly demonstrate just how useful news stories are on your English learning journey. I'll walk you through each article and point out some handy words along the way. Stick around for a short quiz at the end to see what you've picked up!

How can the news help your English?

I'm sure you don't need me to tell you that there are a lot of news websites out there, not to mention newspapers, magazines and so on. The great thing is you can choose your news source depending on the type of articles you're interested in and the vocabulary you want to learn.

- If you work in finance, you might read **The Economist**.
- People who are interested in science might read articles from **New Scientist**.

But news articles are excellent for learning general English, too. Most articles are written for ordinary people, like you and me, so they use everyday language. They're usually jam-packed with useful vocabulary, collocations and phrases, and many are full of phrasal verbs and idioms, especially if they include interviews with people.

Using the news to study English isn't just for advanced learners; here are a few excellent news sites for beginner and intermediate English learners -

- **Time for Kids** offers engaging content in clear language, helping ESL learners with vocabulary and comprehension: <https://www.timeforkids.com/?u=>
- **The Voice of America Learning English** site provides accessible news and feature stories in simplified English so learners improve their listening, reading and comprehension skills: <https://learningenglish.voanews.com/>



1 The Failure of Self-checkouts

I'm going to start with the story about **self-checkouts**. This story is from the BBC, and it's available for everyone to read.

You can read the full article here: t.ly/s40th

I'm only going to go over the first few paragraphs of the story in this lesson, so if you want to continue reading, go and check it out on the BBC website.

Self-checkouts: love them or hate them? I love them until I hear '**unexpected item in the bagging area**' (which I hear almost every time I use them). But let's see what the article from the BBC has to say.

First, here's the headline -

'It hasn't delivered': The spectacular failure of self-checkout technology

I want to draw your attention to the verb '**to deliver**' in the headline. In this context, 'to deliver' means to do or achieve something that was promised.

1. **to deliver** v /dɪˈlɪvə/ - to do or achieve something that was promised
 - Alice has promised to increase sales and I'm sure she'll **deliver**.

So, the headline says that self-checkout technology hasn't done what was expected.

Under the headline, we have the **lede**. We can spell it two different ways (**L-E-D-E** or **L-E-A-D**), but both are pronounced the same: /li:d/. This is the first sentence or paragraph of a news story that gives you an overview and is supposed to make you keep reading. Let's see if this lede **delivers**.



Unstaffed tills were supposed to revolutionise shopping. Now, both retailers and customers are bagging many self-checkout kiosks.

I want to talk to you about a **pun** in that lede. Puns often use a word with two meanings in a funny way. News writers love puns, but they can often be difficult to understand for people who are learning a language.

This pun involves the word 'bagging', which is in this sentence: **Now, both retailers and customers are bagging many self-checkout kiosks.** In this context, 'to bag' means to decide not to use something and to use something else instead. But of course, 'to bag' also means **'to put something into a bag'**, which is something that you generally do at a self-checkout!

2. **to bag** v /bæg/ - 1. to decide not to use something and to use something else instead
2. to put something into a bag
- Please **bag** your items carefully so they don't break.

So, are you following the story? Self-checkout technology has failed! It was supposed to completely change how we shop, but shops and customers are deciding not to use it. I wonder why? Let's read on. Here's the next paragraph.

It's a common sight at many retail stores: a queue of people, waiting to use a self-checkout kiosk, doing their best to remain patient as a lone store worker attends to multiple malfunctioning machines. The frustration mounts while a dozen darkened, roped-off and cashier-less tills sit in the background.

I have never identified with anything more. Standing in a queue, watching a poor store worker running from one checkout to another while the other tills are empty. The language in the paragraph from the news story is very expressive. Let's take a look at some of it.

a lone store worker

When we talk about '**lone**' people or things, we mean they are 'alone'. It always comes before the noun and, in this case, it emphasises that there is nobody else around to help.

3. **lone** adj /ləʊn/ - without other people or things

- The **lone** tree in the field stands without any other trees around it.

multiple malfunctioning machines

This is some great **alliteration** - the quick repetition of the sound /m/. It's a literary device in which the same starting sound of words in a sentence or line is repeated close together (often consonant sounds). It's often used in advertising because our brains love repeated sounds: Coca-Cola, Krispy Kreme, etc.

Let's break down these words.

4. **multiple** adj /'mʌltɪpl/ - many

- We bought **multiple** pizzas for the party.

Note: 'To malfunction' is a great high-level verb to talk about machines not working properly.

5. **malfunctioning** adj /mæl'fʌŋkʃnɪŋ/ - not working correctly

- The **malfunctioning** printer doesn't print in colour.

6. **machine** n /mə'ʃi:n/ - a tool that does a job for us, often making work easier

- We use various **machines** to make the different parts we need.

Next up, we have the collocation '**the frustration mounts**'.



7. **frustration mounts** /frʌs'treɪʃn maʊnts/ - frustration increases

'To mount' /maʊnt/ means **to gradually increase**. Using 'to mount' instead of 'to increase' makes the sentence sing! You'll also often see the collocation written like this: **mounting frustration**.

- There was **mounting frustration** this morning as the delay continued.

Alright, let's look at the last part of this article. Remember to follow the link in the description box if you want to continue reading.

For shoppers, self-checkout was supposed to provide convenience and speed. Retailers hoped it would usher in a new age of cost savings. Their thinking: why pay six employees when you could pay one to oversee customers at self-service registers, as they do their own labour of scanning and bagging for free?

Retailers hoped it would usher in a new age of cost savings. What a great sentence for learning English!

First, the phrasal verb **to usher in** /ˌʌʃə(r) 'ɪn/.

Remember: phrasal verbs are often less formal than similar single-word verbs.

8. **to usher in** phr v /ˌʌʃə(r) 'ɪn/ - (a formal phrasal verb) to be at the start of something new or to cause something new to start

In the article, we saw that self-checkout was supposed **to usher in** a new age of cost savings. You'll often see 'to usher in' followed by expressions like 'a new age', 'a new era', 'a period' or 'a time'.

- The policies **ushered in a time** of economic growth.



So, what do you think? Is self-checkout technology a good thing or a bad thing? I go back and forth — sometimes I love it, sometimes I find it really frustrating. (Or, I feel a sense of **mounting frustration**!) I hope that article helped demonstrate how good a resource news articles can be when you're learning English.

Now, it's time to take a look at our second article.

2 Welsh Tidy Mouse

Notice the title here doesn't follow our normal adjective order, which would be - **quality (tidy) + origin (Welsh)**

This is a stylistic choice as it shifts the emphasis onto Welsh and sounds catchier than 'Tidy Welsh Mouse'.

This article is from **The Guardian** newspaper and it's free to read online. You can find the full article here: t.ly/4bTSN

Again, I'm only going to read a part of it with you, so you can finish it after this lesson if you want to. This article is stuffed with **phrasal verbs**. I know phrasal verbs can be tricky for English students, but seeing them used in context is one of the best ways to learn them and get an idea of how to use them naturally. There is a lot of other great vocabulary in this article, too.

Let's look at the headline:

Mouse secretly filmed tidying man's shed every night

Well, I think that headline gives the story away! Yes, a mouse has been tidying someone's shed.

9. **shed** n /ʃed/ - a small building, usually in someone's garden, used for storing things like tools and bikes

- My **shed** is full of rubbish that I don't even use!



Underneath the headline, we see this sentence:

Photographer who noticed his items were mysteriously moving around discovered an industrious rodent was organising his workbench

I want to point out two words in this part.

10. **industrious** adj /ɪnˈdʌstriəs/ - hard-working

- The **industrious** student spent hours studying in the library.

11. **rodent** n /ˈrəʊdnt/ - the name for the group of animals that includes mice, rats and squirrels

- I don't know what was in the kitchen, but I'm sure it was some sort of **rodent**!

I find the image of an '**industrious rodent**' so funny. Anyway, let's look at the next part of the article.

A mouse has been filmed secretly tidying up a man's shed almost every night for two months.

Wildlife photographer Rodney Holbrook noticed that objects he left out of place were being mysteriously put back where they belonged overnight.

How convenient that the man who owns the shed is a wildlife photographer! So, this man goes to bed with a messy shed and wakes up with a tidy one. Isn't that the dream? I wonder if the mouse has any friends who'll come and do my shed.

I want to talk about two phrasal verbs from that part of the article:



The first is **to tidy up**. The particle **'up'** doesn't change the meaning of the verb 'to tidy' - We could simply say, 'A mouse has been filmed tidying a man's shed', but the preposition 'up' adds a shade of meaning and implies that the tidying is complete. You tidy everything.

12. **to tidy up** phr v /ˌtaɪdi (j) 'ʌp/ - to make something look neat and clean
- We should **tidy up** before Randi and Ron come over.

The second phrasal verb is **'to put back'**. This was the sentence from the article: 'objects he left out of place were being mysteriously **put back** where they belonged overnight.'

13. **to put back** phr v /ˌpʊt 'bæk/ - to return an object to where it was before it was moved
- **Put** those biscuits **back** on the shelf! We already have some at home.

Let's look at the next part now.

Holbrook, from Builth Wells in Powys, Wales, set up a night vision camera on his workbench to find out what was happening, and captured footage reminiscent of the 2007 animated movie Ratatouille, where a rodent secretly cooks at a restaurant.

Have you seen Ratatouille? This does sound like a real-life version, doesn't it? There are two more excellent phrasal verbs in that passage. Can you find them in this sentence?

Holbrook set up a night vision camera on his workbench to find out what was happening.



The first one is **to set up**.

14. **to set up** phr v /ˌset 'ʌp/ - to prepare some equipment so it's ready to use

- I **set up** all of my video equipment before I start filming.

The second one was **to find out**.

15. **to find out** phr v /ˌfaɪnd 'aʊt/ - to get information about something

- I want **to find out** who is tidying my shed!

There are a few more words I want to talk about from that part of the article, too. First, we have **footage**.

16. **footage** n /'fʊtɪdʒ/ - a film that shows a particular event

- She used a drone to capture **footage** of the wildlife.

We often say
that we 'capture
footage'.

And the other is the word **reminiscent**, followed by the preposition '**of**'. This is quite a formal word; we wouldn't use it in everyday speech, but you'll see it often in writing.

17. **reminiscent** (of) adj /ˌremɪ'nɪsnt/ - reminding you of something

- The smell of freshly baked bread was **reminiscent** of her childhood.

Now, let's look at the next part of the article.

Holbrook, 75, told the BBC: "It has been going on for months. I call him Welsh Tidy Mouse. At first, I noticed that some food that I was putting out for the birds was ending up in some old shoes I was storing in the shed, so I set up a camera."

Night vision footage showed the seemingly conscientious rodent gathering clothes pegs, corks, nuts and bolts, and placing them in a tray on Holbrook's workbench.

It's been happening for months! That mouse has really moved into Rodney Holbrook's shed. The mouse started by moving some bird food around and then began to move other small objects, too!

Let's look at two phrasal verbs from that part of the article.

First, we had **to go on**, which we saw in the sentence: **It has been going on for months.**

18. **to go on** phr v /ˌɡəʊ (w) 'ɒn/ - to continue over a period of time

- The meeting seemed **to go on** forever, stretching well into the afternoon.

Then we had **to end up**, which was in the sentence: **I noticed that some food that I was putting out for the birds was ending up in some old shoes.**

19. **to end up** phr v /ˌend 'ʌp/ - to finally be in a place, often one you didn't plan to be in

- After getting lost on the hike, they **ended up** at a beautiful, hidden waterfall.

So, according to Holbrook, the bird food wasn't where it was supposed to be because every night, it ended up in some old shoes.

And there's one phrase that I just can't resist talking about - '**the seemingly conscientious rodent**'.



20. **seemingly** adv /'si:mɪŋli/ - appearing to have a quality or to be something, though we are not sure

- The road was **seemingly** endless, winding all the way up the mountain.

21. **conscientious** adj /ˌkɒnʃiˈenʃəs/ - doing something carefully and with effort

- Marteen was **conscientious** in her efforts to recycle and reduce waste.

And you know the word '**rodent**' from earlier in the lesson. So we have a '**seemingly conscientious rodent**' - seemingly because, of course, we can't ask the mouse if it likes to do things carefully, but it certainly appears to. I think the writer had a lot of fun with this article. And I hope you had fun reading it with me.

QUIZ!

Choose the correct answer for each question.

1. The word 'lede' in journalism refers to:
 - a. the main headline of a story
 - b. the concluding remarks
 - c. the opening sentence or paragraph
2. Holbrook _____ up a night vision camera to _____ what was happening.
 - a. set / find out
 - b. sets / finds out
 - c. setting / find out
3. An 'industrious rodent' refers to a mouse that is:
 - a. lazy and unproductive
 - b. hard-working and busy
 - c. destructive and bothersome
4. What is the meaning of the phrasal verb 'to tidy up'?
 - a. to make a place dirty
 - b. to leave things out of place.
 - c. to clean and arrange things neatly
5. They decided to _____ the advertising plan in favour of a different approach.
 - a. bag
 - b. purchase
 - c. distribute
6. 'Mounting frustration' indicates that frustration is:
 - a. decreasing over time
 - b. staying the same
 - c. increasing gradually
7. To _____ a new phase in her life, she moved to a different city and started a new job.
 - a. end
 - b. usher in
 - c. walk away from
8. The machine has been _____ frequently, causing delays in the manufacturing process.
 - a. mounting
 - b. malfunctioning
 - c. industrious
9. The only person in the office was a _____ employee working late.
 - a. seemingly
 - b. multiple
 - c. lone
10. What is alliteration?
 - a. repeated initial consonant sounds
 - b. a marketing strategy
 - c. the use of rodents to clean a shed

The End!

11) 2) 3) 4) 5) 6) 7) 8) 9) 10) 11)

